

Figure 3: Core building blocks of SAIF

not static. Models are updated, prompts are refined, user behaviour changes, and attackers discover new techniques. SAIF therefore emphasises adaptive controls and fast feedback loops. Organisations should conduct red-team exercises, review model outputs, track incidents, collect user feedback, and adjust policies when risk patterns change. An example is an insurance company using AI to summarise claims documents. If reviewers notice that the model occasionally omits critical exclusions or misinterprets handwritten notes, the feedback should trigger improvement actions such as retraining, prompt revision, better document-quality checks, or mandatory human validation for complex claims. Governance becomes stronger when operational evidence continuously improves the control environment.

Contextualising AI risk within business processes: The final building block is perhaps the most important for governance. AI risk cannot be assessed only at the model level; it must be understood in the business context where the model operates. A low-risk model used for internal document classification is very different from an AI system that recommends credit decisions, guides medical triage, or executes supplier payments. SAIF encourages leaders to connect technical controls with business impact, customer trust, legal obligations, financial exposure, and reputational risk. For example, an AI procurement agent that can create purchase orders must have spending limits, approval workflows, segregation of duties, and exception handling. The risk is not merely that the model may produce an incorrect answer but that the business process may act on it without sufficient control.

Practical operating model for SAIF adoption

A practical SAIF operating model should begin with executive sponsorship and end with measurable control assurance. The CEO sets the tone that AI must be innovative, secure, ethical, and aligned with enterprise strategy. The CTO and AI head shape the technical architecture, model lifecycle, engineering practices, and AI enablement roadmap. The CIO ensures that AI platforms integrate with enterprise systems, service management, data platforms, and operational support. The chief security officer defines the threat model, security controls, monitoring approach, and incident response playbooks. The CFO validates funding, cost governance, value tracking, and financial risk. The chief strategy officer ensures that AI adoption supports the organisation's competitive direction and long-term transformation priorities.

The process should include an AI intake board, risk classification, data review, model approval, security architecture review, red-team testing, release readiness assessment, production monitoring, periodic audit, and retirement procedures. This may sound extensive, but it should be scaled based on risk. A low-impact internal productivity tool may require a lighter review, while a customer-facing AI system that influences financial or operational decisions should go through a more rigorous control path. The strength of SAIF lies in this balance: it does not slow AI unnecessarily, but it ensures that speed is supported by discipline.

RASCI matrix for developing and handling SAIF in an organisation

The following RASCI matrix illustrates how senior leadership roles can participate in defining, implementing, governing, and continuously improving SAIF. In this matrix, R means Responsible, A equals Accountable, S is Supportive, C means Consulted, and I is Informed.